

Comments for Planning Application DM2025/01591

Application Summary

Application Number: DM2025/01591

Address: Ambulance Station Dorset Road Belmont SM2 6JH

Proposal: Change of use from Sui Generis (Ambulance Station) to mixed use Classes F1 (Places of Worship) and F2 (Community Hub) involving the erection of a part one, part two storey front and side extension, increase in height to part of building and provision of cycle and refuse stores.

Case Officer: Polly Davidson

Customer Details

Name: Mr Swapnil Bhonsle

Address: 61 Cheam Road Epsom KT17 3EG

Comment Details

Commenter Type:

Stance: Customer objects to the Planning Application

Comment Reasons:

Comment: Dear Planning Officer,

I write to formally object to planning application DM2025/01591 for the change of use of the former ambulance station at 18 Dorset Road to a mixed-use Place of Worship (Class F1) and Community Hub (Class F2), together with extensions and increased height.

My objection is made on clear material planning grounds, as set out below.

1. Conflict with Policies Protecting Residential Amenity

The application site is located within a predominantly residential area characterised by low-intensity uses. The proposed development represents a significant intensification of activity, particularly during evenings and weekends, when religious services and community events typically occur.

The likely frequency of gatherings, vehicular arrivals/departures, and associated activity would materially harm neighbouring residential amenity through increased noise, disturbance, general activity, and light pollution. The absence of detailed operational controls (including enforceable limits on hours, event frequency, and maximum occupancy) gives rise to substantial uncertainty regarding the real-world impacts.

Development plan policies require that proposals do not result in unacceptable harm to the living conditions of neighbouring occupiers. In this case, the scale and nature of the proposed use is incompatible with the quiet residential character of the immediate area.

2. Severe Impact on Highway Safety and Parking Stress

The application site is not located within a town centre, nor is it supported by infrastructure appropriate for a high-intensity community destination use. A place of worship and community hub will predictably generate concentrated peak demand before and after services and events.

Local streets are constrained and already experience on-street parking pressure. The proposal

fails to robustly demonstrate that:

On-site parking provision (if any) is sufficient to meet peak demand;

Overspill parking will not occur in surrounding residential roads;

Pedestrian and vehicle conflict points will not increase; and

Emergency access will remain uncompromised during large gatherings.

Highway safety is a material consideration of significant weight. Where parking demand materially exceeds supply, and overspill parking is likely, the resulting congestion and obstruction can constitute sustainable grounds for refusal. The application does not contain a sufficiently detailed or independently verified transport assessment demonstrating that impacts would be neutral or acceptable.

3. Unsustainable and Inappropriate Location

Planning policy directs high footfall community uses toward accessible, sustainable locations such as town centres or sites well served by public transport and designed for visitor accommodation.

This site sits within a residential context without the infrastructure normally associated with a regional or sub-regional worship facility. The proposal would create a destination venue within a residential street network not designed to accommodate concentrated visitor flows. This runs counter to sustainable spatial planning principles and risks creating ongoing land use conflict.

4. Harm to Character and Overdevelopment

The proposal includes physical extensions and increased height in addition to the material change of use. When combined with intensified activity levels, the cumulative effect is a fundamental shift in the function and character of the site.

The development would introduce a level of built form and operational intensity inconsistent with the established pattern of development. This constitutes overdevelopment of the site in practical planning terms, particularly when assessed against the prevailing residential grain and scale.

5. Absence of Robust Mitigation and Enforcement Mechanisms

The application lacks sufficient detail regarding:

Maximum capacity of the venue;

Frequency and scale of services/events;

Traffic marshals or controlled parking strategies;

Noise management plans;

Servicing and refuse management arrangements;

Mechanisms to prevent ad hoc large-scale events.

Without clearly defined, enforceable conditions supported by evidence, there is a material risk of incremental intensification beyond what is assessed at application stage. The Planning Authority must assess the proposal based on its worst-case realistic operational scenario, not aspirational management statements.

Given the scale of likely impacts and the absence of demonstrably effective mitigation, the proposal fails to provide adequate certainty that residential amenity, highway safety, and local character would be protected.

For the reasons outlined above, the proposal conflicts with key development plan principles relating to residential amenity, highway safety, sustainable location, and character. I respectfully request that planning permission be refused.

Yours faithfully,